Democracy in Exile: The Failed Opposition to Nazism

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HISTORY 3FF3: Nazi Germany

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In 1933, the Social Democratic Party of Germany (SPD) was banned by the Nazi regime, marking the destruction of the largest democratic force in the Weimar Republic. As a result, the party's leadership went into exile and attempted to continue the struggle against Nazism from abroad under the name of the Exile Organization of the Social Democratic Party of Germany (SOPADE). Yet despite being well organized and surviving the entirety of the war, SOPADE failed to mount any significant opposition to the Nazi regime. This essay analyzes how and why this failure occurred, arguing that SOPADE's ineffectiveness was caused by both ideological rigidity and the constraints of the regime. The moderate, legalist mindset that had guided the Weimar-era SPD remained with the party in exile and left them paralyzed when faced with the realities of a totalitarian regime. At the same time, the brutal repression of opposition within Germany and its conquered territories made any form of active resistance nearly impossible. By following the SPD's downfall and reorganization into SOPADE, this essay aims to demonstrate how the party's unwavering commitment to democracy went from the SPD's defining advantage to being its biggest weakness.

Fall of the SPD

In the years leading up to Hitler's takeover, the Reichstag was facing a crisis. Tensions were high due to the effects of the Great Depression, and the governing coalition, headed by SPD chairman and Chancellor Hermann Müller, collapsed. In March 1930, Germany's trade unions had pushed the SPD to refuse a compromise which would have delayed the refinancing of unemployment insurance. As a result, Müllers cabinet fell, and he was replaced by the chairman of the Centre Party, Heinrich Brüning.[1] The Brüning cabinet, however, was even weaker than the previous one, and in July, the SPD voted against a

[1] Heinrich August Winkler, "Choosing the Lesser Evil: The German Social Democrats and the Fall of the Weimar Republic," *Journal of Contemporary History* 25, no. 2 (1990): 205–7, https://doi.org/10.1177/002200949002500203.

measure bringing it down and triggering an election.[2] This election, held in September 1930, marked a major shift in Weimar history. At this point, the world was one year into the Great Depression. Amid mass unemployment,[3] Germans moved to the political extremes, rallying behind the Communist Party of Germany (KPD) and the National Socialist German Workers' Party (NSDAP/Nazis). When the results of the election were counted, the KPD and NSDAP achieved their largest electoral victories to date. The SPD walked away with 143 seats, still the most in the Reichstag. The Nazis came in second, rising to 107 seats from their previous 12, and the Communists won 77, meaning 184 members were extremists who would not cooperate with any government.[4] Following the election and seeing how much Nazi support had grown, the SPD adopted the "Policy of Toleration" and decided to support Brüning's return. Their support for the second Brüning cabinet was not rooted in confidence in the chancellor; rather, the SPD saw this as the "lesser evil" to Nazi rule. And so, the SPD began supporting measures that it would never support if it were in a position to vote how it truly wanted. For example, in March 1931, the party abstained from a vote which resulted in the construction of a new battleship, going against the party's anti-militarist principles.[5] Additionally, in 1932, the party campaigned for the re-election of former Field Marshall and conservative President Paul von Hindenburg, who was running against Hitler himself, once again choosing the "lesser evil".[6]

This begs the question: if the moderate parties to the right of the SPD were so unreliable and willing to put democracy in harm's way, why didn't the SPD create a left-wing coalition instead and include the KPD? Although both parties claimed to represent the working class, there existed between them deep ideological divisions and hostility. The SPD supported the Weimar Republic and wanted to see

[2] Winkler, "Choosing the Lesser Evil," 207–8.
[3] Pamela E. Swett and S. Jonathan Wiesen, "Nazi Germany: Society, Culture and Politics" (Bloomsbury Academic, 2024), 42.
[4] James K. Pollock, "The German Reichstag Elections of 1930," *The American Political Science Review* 24, no. 4 (1930): 991–92, https://doi.org/10.2307/1946755.
[5] Winkler, "Choosing the Lesser Evil," 211.
[6] Winkler, "Choosing the Lesser Evil," 213.

it preserved, while the KPD supported Soviet-style revolution, being a member of the Comintern and receiving orders from Moscow. They believed the SPD to be "social fascists" and saw them as just another bourgeois party propping up the capitalist system. This culminated in "Bloody May" in 1929, when the SPD-led police force in Prussia had violently suppressed KPD demonstrations, killing 33 members.[7] After the SPD adopted its toleration policy, it confirmed the KPD's belief that the SPD was the main enemy defending the capitalist order. By 1932, cooperation between the two parties was unthinkable. This inability to adapt or build alliances on the left would follow the party into exile.

Into Exile

In July 1932, another election was held, which resulted in a Nazi win,[8] and a few months later, Hindenburg appointed Hitler as chancellor.[9] In March 1933, Hitler proposed the Enabling Act; by this time, the KPD had already been outlawed, and many SPD members had been detained.[10] Despite this, the remaining SPD members showed up for the vote on the bill, where SPD chairman Otto Wels delivered a speech declaring the SPD would not engage in violent opposition to the Nazis' apparent revolution, but affirmed the party would not vote in favour of eliminating the Reichstag.[11] After the votes were tallied, SPD members were the only ones who voted against the Enabling Act.[12] Within weeks after the bill's

[7] Winkler, "Choosing the Lesser Evil," 215–17.
[8] Jerome G. Kerwin, "The German Reichstag Elections of July 31, 1932," *American Political Science Review* 26, no. 5 (1932): 922, https://doi.org/10.2307/1947146.
[9] Swett and Wiesen, "Nazi Germany," 50.
[10] Swett and Wiesen, "Nazi Germany," 59.
[11] "Speech by the Social Democrat Otto Wels against the Passage of the 'Enabling Act' (March 23, 1933)," accessed November 4, 2025, https://ghdi.ghi-dc.org/docpage.cfm?docpage_id=2262.
[12] Frank McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany," 5th print, Cambridge Perspectives in History (Cambridge Univ. Pr, 2006), 3.

passing, the Nazis had outlawed the SPD, seized their assets, and arrested thousands of members, sending them to concentration camps.[13]

While many SPD members were detained, those who weren't fled into exile, initially settling in Prague, where they quickly established an underground network to smuggle information in and out of Germany and took on the name SOPADE.[14] Their initial strategy was the "enlightenment campaign"; they wanted to achieve liberal-democratic revolution by enlightening the German public about the true nature of the Nazi regime by smuggling anti-Nazi pamphlets and newspapers into Germany.[15] One group involved in this strategy was the "Red Shock Troop", a group of 3,000, mostly university students in Berlin, who published a newspaper funded by SOPADE, which suggested that the Nazi regime was weak and on the brink of overthrow by German workers. However, in December 1933, the leaders of the Red Shock Troop were arrested and detained in concentration camps. SOPADE continued to fund resistance groups in Berlin, including another newspaper called "Socialist Action", but in January 1935, they too were stopped. By 1938, the Gestapo had become so efficient at quelling this kind of resistance that SOPADE determined it to be too dangerous and ceased these operations.[16]

As the Red Shock Troop papers had said, the party started operating on the belief of Marxist Determinism, that the Nazis were a natural step in the move towards socialism and believed "[i]n the end, the crisis of capitalism which had put Hitler in power would cause his downfall."[17] This did not mean they

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[13] McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany," 3; "SPD Members Arrested and Sent to Concentration Camps (May 16, 1933)," German History in Documents and Images, accessed September 19, 2025, https://germanhistorydocs.org/en/nazi-germany-1933-1945/spd-members-arrested-and-sent-to-concentration-camps-may-16-1933.
[14] McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany," 3; Lewis J. Edinger, "German Exile Politics: The Social Democratic Executive Committee in the Nazi Era. By Lewis J. Edinger. (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press. 1956. Pp. Xiii, 329. $4.25.)," *American Political Science Review* 51, no. 1 (1957): 38, https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055400232486.
[15] McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany," 3; Edinger, "German Exile Politics," 44–45.
[16] McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany," 4.
[17] Edinger, "German Exile Politics," 113.

believed Hitler would simply disappear overnight, but that his promises to the German people would not come to fruition and the disillusionment would lead to stronger opposition; they believed that the only way Hitler would be overthrown was through a coup supported by the German army.[18] This faith in historical inevitability became a defining feature of SOPADE's politics in exile, providing moral justification for their passivity.

SOPADE Stagnation

By 1934, SOPADE had survived a year in exile and established itself as the continuation of the SPD; however, its actions revealed that it had not adapted to the new political reality. When in Prague, SOPADE organized itself into a structured, centralized body that aimed to mirror the Weimar-era SPD, demonstrating how the party saw Hitler as a temporary step in the inevitable course of history. As a result, SOPADE leaders believed their main task to be preserving party unity and preparing themselves to take back Germany once the inevitable happened.[19] Briefly, however, the party seemed to promote a more radical approach in the 1934 Prague Manifesto, which advocated for the old system to be destroyed and replaced with a new state with socialized industries. However, the manifesto was published without interparty discussion, and in 1936, it was retracted and replaced with a new one, once again advocating for the restoration of the Republic.[20] After SOPADE determined that the enlightenment campaign was too dangerous, the party dedicated itself to the creation of reports analyzing the morale of the German public.[21] While these reports were indeed insightful on the sentiment within Germany, the move shows how SOPADE became simply an observer rather than an actor, and that the leadership was unwilling to abandon its faith in resistance through legal, non-violent means.

[18] Edinger, "German Exile Politics," 113–15; McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany," 4.
[19] Edinger, "German Exile Politics," 38–39.
[20] Mary Nolan, "Antifascism under Fascism: German Visions and Voices," *New German Critique*, no. 67 (1996): 48, https://doi.org/10.2307/827776.
[21] McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany," 4; "The Sopade Report on the Mood among Workers (September 1938)," accessed November 6, 2025, https://ghdi.ghi-dc.org/sub_document.cfm?document_id=1553.

Furthermore, while in exile, the broader left still could not find a way to unify. Much of the KPD remained in Germany and had established underground networks through which to keep operating. However, this came at a cost; between 1933 and 1939, the regime had arrested more than 150,000 Communists and executed 30,000.[22] At the same time, a small left-wing faction called "New Beginning" started to form; they claimed that unity between socialists and communists was the only way Hitler would be defeated and believed that leftist disunity created the conditions for Hitler's rise in the first place.[23] SOPADE, however, rejected any ideas of giving in to anyone to the left, believing "[t]he great return to common sense [was] progressing."[24] This continued disunity pointed to a broader issue, though. As historian Mary Nolan points out, both parties were blind to the fact that class divisions were not the main factor in the Nazi regime and that anti-semitism and racism were the central dynamics at play. They were unable to grasp that "[n]either social democracy nor liberalism could easily accommodate racial politics and rationalized genocide."[25] As a result, SOPADE became more of an archive than a revolutionary movement. After all, the SPD was a party built for parliament and not for underground resistance. Their view of themselves as constitutional defenders ended up being their biggest liability.

Ideological Rigidity vs. Circumstantial Constraint

SOPADE's failure in mounting any effective resistance against the Nazi regime can be understood through the intersection of ideology and circumstance. On one side, party leadership carried into exile the party's commitments to legality and rationality even after the regime in power had rejected these values altogether. While they recognized that the Nazi regime would not fall without some sort of violent uprising, they did nothing to contribute to this reality,[26] following constitutional norms that had long been

[22] McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany," 4–5.
[23] Nolan, "Antifascism under Fascism," 49; McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany," 4.
[24] Edinger, "German Exile Politics," 150.
[25] Nolan, "Antifascism under Fascism," 51–52.
[26] McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany", 4.

forgotten. This ideological rigidity made true resistance almost impossible; instead of mobilizing or cooperating among the left, SOPADE continued to issue reports and manifestos, holding onto faith that the political order they cherished would soon be restored. Despite this, ideological rigidity alone cannot explain the party's failures. Circumstantial constraints also played a significant role in making resistance difficult. By 1938, the Gestapo had built such an extensive surveillance network that almost every underground socialist organization within the country had been destroyed.[27] Under these circumstances, any significant attempt to mount coordinated resistance would have resulted in immediate annihilation; even if SOPADE adopted a more radical approach, its actual capacity to implement such a thing was virtually nonexistent. Ultimately, the party's faith in the eventual collapse of the regime gave SOPADE moral justification for being passive. At the same time, the repression within Germany and the regime's success in isolating any possible opposition made it so that any resistance was suicidal. The SPD's values and moral convictions were kept intact, but without the institutions, resources, and a public free to support these convictions, those same values did nothing but paralyze the party.

Conclusion

The exile of the SPD shows us the limits of a party built to defend democracy through legal means in a context where legality and democracy no longer exist. The party's leadership went into exile with the same convictions that had defined Weimar-era democratic socialism: reason, constitutionalism, and gradual reform, but in a landscape that no longer valued these convictions, their beliefs became weaknesses instead of strengths. Indeed, structural repression and extensive surveillance made resistance next to impossible, but it was ideological continuity that ensured SOPADE would never even attempt to adapt, showing that, from multiple angles, effective resistance to the Nazis would never happen without outside influence.

[27] McDonough, "Opposition and Resistance in Nazi Germany", 4.

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